

Wedlake Bell

Complete firm and application research — heritage & culture, art and luxury law, private wealth, digital assets, reputation management, responsible business, growth and personal application notes.

Heritage: Founded 1780
Core sectors: Art & Luxury, Private Wealth, Reputation Management
2025 trainee retention: 100%
Secondments: No international secondment options currently offered

1. Firm Overview & Heritage	—
2. Culture	—
3. Sectors — Art & Luxury	—
4. Private Wealth	—
5. Digital Assets	—
6. Litigation — Media & Reputation Management	—
7. Philanthropy & Museums	—
8. Recent Insights (Selected)	—
9. Firm News & Growth	—
10. Responsible Business	—
11. Social Impact	—
12. Equality & Diversity	—
13. Qualities Sought	—
14. Personal Fit Notes	—

1. Firm Overview & Heritage

- Heritage dating back to 1780
- Positions itself around change and opportunity, balanced against long tradition
- Apprentices get lots of responsibility to project-manage and run small matters, gaining exposure to real "lawyering" early on
- Culture of approachability that "doesn't feel hierarchical"
- No international secondment options currently on offer

2. Culture

- No sense that trainees are in competition with each other; the recruitment process is described as "really human"
- Social life is described as "positively pumping" — frequent, well-attended firmwide and team social events
- Highlights include monthly firm drinks, a ski trip in winter, a walking trip in summer, and the odd theatre trip — the firm is reportedly generous at these events, seen as important by management
- Supervisors are rated as approachable and encouraging, and are said to respect the contribution and input of juniors and trainees — described by one junior as one of the most supportive work environments they've worked in
- One team member noted appreciating being able to finish at 6pm most days
- Values described as "personal yet powerful" — cross-border transactions and complex issues, but small enough to work closely with clients and know their situations well
- Advice style is straightforward — avoiding jargon and speaking plainly
- Culture is always collaborative: listen, adapt, and seek solutions together to achieve shared goals

3. Sectors — Art & Luxury

Art and luxury assets are framed as a form of personal story, family legacy, and cultural and personal meaning — holding financial as well as cultural and historic value. Clients include collectors, charities, and landed estates; the work can carry national importance.

WATCHES, JEWELLERY, WINE, SHOES	HERITAGE ASSETS & GIFTS	ACCEPTANCE IN LIEU	CLASSIC CARS (CGT-EXEMPT)	SUCCESSION & LIFETIME GIFTS
COLLATERAL FOR LENDING	DISPUTES & IP	SALE & PURCHASE DISPUTES		

Selected cases & examples

- UK export controls for cultural goods; working with national museums on tax-free private treaty sales of art and cultural objects
- Advising on tax-efficient transfers of heritage assets, including world-record auction results
- Acting in a cross-border sale of a significant painting by a leading impressionist artist — involving complex negotiations, export licensing and catalogue inclusion
- Advising a collector in a dispute with a leading auction house over the sale of a high-value painting
- Ongoing advice to an artist on legacy planning, charitable governance, IP rights, and international exhibition arrangements
- Representing individuals in disputes against galleries involving misrepresentation, consumer law breaches, and potential regulatory implications

Art and luxury markets are described as truly international, much like the lives of many of the firm's clients — reinforcing why this sector connects closely with the firm's cross-border private wealth work.

4. Private Wealth

Private wealth work is facing new pressures: Inheritance Tax reforms, Capital Gains Tax increases, and the removal of long-standing reliefs for non-domiciled individuals. These sit alongside the complexities of modern family life — blended households, second marriages, international mobility, an ageing population, and vulnerable beneficiaries — all requiring a thoughtful, sensitive approach.

The firm provides strategic advice on succession, tax-efficient wealth extraction, shareholder protection, and future-proofing client affairs. Client relationships often span generations — second, third, even fourth generations of the same family — allowing deep trust and continuity of advice that evolves with each generation's needs.

Recent experience

- Advising shareholders of a long-standing family business on personal tax and estate planning during a high-value business sale, and establishing a family investment company to protect sale proceeds
- Acting as lead advisers to an ultra-high-net-worth couple and their family office, coordinating estate planning across multiple jurisdictions and advising on trust structures and governance
- Managing the complex estate of the founder of a major UK asset management firm, securing significant Inheritance Tax savings through business property relief and deed of variation strategies
- Restructuring a family-owned hotel business to preserve business property relief ahead of inheritance tax changes, coordinating a trust termination and partnership formation

5. Digital Assets

As lives are increasingly lived online, NFTs, crypto and online accounts are often overlooked in estate planning — proper planning is needed so executors and trustees can manage the practical hurdles of a "digital estate."

- Incorporating digital assets into wills and trust documents
- Ensuring executors have the authority to access and manage online accounts
- Understanding how licensing agreements affect ownership and transfer
- Using secure storage and communication tools to protect sensitive data

Recent experience

- Advised a high-net-worth individual on succession planning for a digital art collection held across multiple platforms, ensuring access and transfer rights
- Advised a family office on structuring a trust for crypto assets

6. Litigation — Media & Reputation Management

Media issues can develop very quickly. The firm's work here focuses on protecting privacy and managing regulatory risk, including:

- Urgent injunctions, online content removal and takedown requests
- Correction and apology negotiations
- Proactive reputation audits
- Regulatory matters and complaints to bodies such as Ofcom, IPSO and the ASA
- Pre-publication and pre-broadcast review to manage legal and reputational risk

7. Philanthropy & Museums

- Museums are facing financial pressure; recent changes to the non-dom tax regime mean philanthropists and donors are less inclined to support them
- The UK relies more on private philanthropy than state support for museums, so tax changes that reduce donors' disposable wealth affect the sector directly
- The UK's tax offer is becoming less appealing, affecting residence, investment and charitable giving decisions; heightened ethical/governance scrutiny for gifts adds a further deterrent for some donors
- The Acceptance in Lieu (AiL) scheme, which allows inheritance tax to be settled with cultural objects, is one incentive supporting this — though overseas donors can still be deterred by import/export difficulties, since it only applies to UK-based arrangements
- The firm's view: the UK needs a tax regime that better supports private generosity, while museums need to uphold trust and ethics to manage risk and encourage giving
- The firm helps by managing reputational risk, supporting long-term relationships, helping structure gifts, and navigating tax-efficient giving schemes

Cultural Gift Scheme: administered by Arts Council England — 30% of agreed value can be set against Income Tax or Capital Gains Tax liability (20% for a corporate donor). Introduced in 2013 to encourage donations to public collections via tax reductions, boosting philanthropy in line with broader government goals.

8. Recent Insights (Selected)

Tax planning — key changes ahead

- The Cash ISA limit is being reduced to £12k from 2027 (no change to Stocks & Shares ISA)
- Tax on income from property, dividends or savings outside an ISA is rising (8.75–10.75%, with property/savings tax up 2% from 2027)
- Up to £325k can be gifted into a trust without IHT to help minimise property value, secure until 2031
- Annual IHT exemption remains £3k/year, plus wedding gift allowances; CGT annual exemption remains stable at £3k

Crypto fraud factsheet

Crypto is mainstream currency but also a fraud target — a digital asset recorded on decentralised blockchain networks, enabling direct transfers without a bank intermediary. Benefits: transparency, speed, global reach. Risks: criminal anonymity and rapid movement of funds, making recovery difficult. Common scam patterns include firms/websites imitating real exchanges, new tokens used to attract and then abandon investment, and phishing/malware attacks. Remedies include disclosure applications (linking accounts to individuals), forensic blockchain analysis tracing asset flow, and freezing injunctions.

Other current insight topics

- Landed estates — should they opt for enhanced employer pension contributions?
- Pension buy-ins, buy-outs and surplus — lessons from Coca-Cola
- UK crypto legal developments to watch in 2026

- Preserving cultural heritage and national treasures
- Protecting artists amid gallery insolvency — terminate agreements pre-insolvency where possible, recover artworks early (proof of ownership becomes harder and costlier later), and be aware that trust-held sale proceeds may leave artists as unsecured creditors without proof of debt
- Lending and the Louvre robbery — a lender's liability for loss/damage depends on contract terms; borrowers aren't automatically required to indemnify loss but do have a duty of care; the Government Indemnity Scheme is a state-backed alternative to insurance, though specialist insurance is often still needed for priceless items — a reminder that even major institutions aren't immune to risk
- Navigating the Takeover Code — key changes effective February 2026
- The importance of young people making wills and Lasting Powers of Attorney
- UK private M&A trends: insights from 2025 and predictions for 2026
- "Heritage Stories" podcast series, exploring the stories behind the firm's own heritage

9. Firm News & Growth

- Growing the charities sector through the hire of a charities/not-for-profit specialist partner and team
- Advised Valent Projects Ltd on a £1.1m AI-related fundraising round
- Private client team continued expansion in 2025 with a new partner hire
- Advised Cairn Financial Advisers LLP and Clear Capital Markets Limited on Medpal AI plc's AIM IPO (digital health tools)
- Shortlisted for a STEP private client award
- Retained 100% of the trainee cohort in 2025, amid a strong year of growth and strategic partner expansion
- Art & Luxury team named in the Spears Legal Index
- Hosted a tech & digital panel discussion

10. Responsible Business

- An internal responsible business working group spans marketing, legal, IT and finance
- Verified carbon footprint goal — net zero by 2050, supported by external partner Auditel
- Achieved zero landfill waste as of February 2025
- 100% renewable electricity
- Minimises travel and encourages online communication; runs a Cycle to Work scheme
- IT audits to improve energy efficiency (e.g. photocopier settings); LED motion-sensor lighting
- Ongoing employee engagement to build awareness of these initiatives

11. Social Impact

- **Concerts for Carers** — improving the mental health of NHS workers and carers through music
- Helped structure and advise on the setup of Svitlo Education, supporting the education of Ukrainians both in Ukraine and elsewhere
- A charity is selected each year, often tied to a personal connection with a staff member — recent partners have included the Wiseman Trust, Cedar House Support Group, and (this year) the Footsteps Foundation, which supports families of disabled children

12. Equality & Diversity

- Describes itself as aiming for true meritocracy
- Apprenticeships: 2 in IT, and 4 law apprenticeships since 2024
- Participates in the Law Society's Diversity Access Scheme, offering work experience for disadvantaged candidates

Diversity stats (SRA Diversity Survey 2025)

- 59% of partners' parents did not attend university
- 67% of solicitors are female
- 36% of partners are female

Full survey: wedlakebell.com — SRA Diversity Survey 2025 (PDF)

13. Qualities Sought

STRATEGIC INSIGHT	HONOURING CLIENTS' INTENTIONS	APPRECIATION FOR FAMILY, VALUES & CONTINUITY	STRUCTURE	LONG-TERM PERSPECTIVE	LISTENING
CLEAR ADVICE	DISCRETION	ADAPTABILITY	CLARITY	PROFESSIONALISM	EXCELLENCE
				MODERN & FORWARD-FACING	GROUNDING
					RESPONSIVE
CURIOUS					

14. Personal Fit Notes

Drafted talking points connecting personal motivations and experience to the firm's positioning — for use/refinement in application answers.

- Art and luxury work allows bringing a long-standing passion for creativity and art history into legal work — including a personal interest in how the sector is evolving through NFTs, digital assets, crypto and IP
- An interest in tax-efficient transfers of heritage assets and gifts to cultural institutions, and whether current incentives (e.g. the 30% Cultural Gift Scheme relief) are genuinely sufficient to encourage this declining activity
- A preference for firms that protect people and legacy, not just money — and for firms protecting artists and creators specifically, not only collectors
- An interest in private client work driven by a people-first approach — wanting a legal career centred on helping families, individuals and businesses
- Strong personal draw to the firm's approachable, non-hierarchical, low-competition culture — a preference for close relationships over being one of many in a very large firm
- An appreciation for the firm's specific, evidence-backed responsible business targets, which are operationally embedded and visible day-to-day (e.g. LED lighting) rather than purely aspirational
- Interest in helping shape the apprenticeship programme, given how new it is at the firm
- A natural sensitivity to reputation management, drawn from marketing experience and audience-facing content work, plus early exposure to commercial decision-making through a family business

Sources: wedlakebell.com insights, news and sector pages; SRA Diversity Survey 2025; published trainee/junior accounts. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.